

Eucalyptus globulus (Myrtaceae)

Eucalyptus, Blue Gum

Eucalyptus, a traditional Aboriginal remedy, is a powerful antiseptic used all over the world for relieving coughs and colds, sore throats, and other infections. It is warming and stimulating, and for many people its scent conjures up days spent in bed during childhood with eucalyptus and other oils smothered on the chest. Eucalyptus is a common ingredient in many over-the-counter cold remedies.



Eucalyptus was first introduced to the West from Australia in the 19th century.

Habitat & Cultivation

Native to Australia, eucalyptus is cultivated in plantations in tropical, subtropical, and temperate areas of the world. Planting can cause ecological problems because the trees absorb huge quantities of water and prevent the growth of native plants. This can be beneficial, however, drying up marshy areas and so reducing the risk of malaria. The leaves are harvested as required and are either dried or distilled for oil.

Related Species

Many other *Eucalyptus* species contain valuable essential oils, including *E. smithii* (p. 207).

Key Constituents

- Volatile oil (cineole, up to 80%)
- Flavonoids
- Tannins
- Resin

Key Actions

- Antiseptic
- Analgesic
- Expectorant

- Stimulates local blood flow
- Insect repellent

Research

- **Essential oil** Extensive research into eucalyptus essential oil during the last 50 years has shown it to have a marked antiseptic action and the ability to dilate the bronchioles (small airways) of the lungs. The action of the essential oil as a whole is stronger than that of its main constituent, cineole.

Traditional & Current Uses

- **Infections** Eucalyptus is a traditional Aboriginal remedy for infections and fevers. It is now used throughout the world for these ailments.
- **Antiseptic** The herb is an antiseptic and is very helpful for colds, flu, and sore throats.
- **Expectorant** Eucalyptus is a strong expectorant, suitable for chest infections, including bronchitis and pneumonia.
- **Warming** The diluted essential oil, applied to the skin as a chest or sinus rub, has a warming and slightly anesthetic effect, helping to relieve respiratory infections. The same effect occurs when the infusion or tincture is used as a gargle.
- **Pain relief** Diluted essential oil applied to the affected area can help relieve rheumatic joints characterized by aching pains and stiffness, as well as neuralgia and some bacterial skin infections.

Self-help Uses

- Congestion, sinus problems, & earache, p. 312.
- Coughs & bronchitis, p. 310.

**Eucalyptus**

An evergreen tree growing to 195 ft (60 m), with a blue-grey trunk and green leaves.

Parts Used

Leaves, which contain antiseptic chemicals, are either dried or used for essential oil.

**Key Preparations & Their Uses**

Caution Do not take essential oil internally except under professional supervision. Do not give to small children or infants.



Lozenges, containing eucalyptus. Take for sore throats.



Capsules, (to make, p. 292). For bronchitis, take a 200 mg capsule 3 times a day.



Inhalation For colds, add 10 drops essential oil to boiling water (p. 297).

Essential oil (to use, p. 297). Use 5 drops diluted with 2 tsp carrier oil as a chest or sinus rub.

Infusion (to make, p. 291). Drink 1 cup (150 ml) 3 times a day for bronchitis.

Tincture (to make, p. 292). For chest coughs, add ½ tsp tincture to ½ cup (100 ml) water and take twice a day.